other elite organizations, whether public or private (Novosad and Werker 2019; Adler-Nissen 2021). These workers possess specialized knowledge and technical expertise in areas such as economics, law, diplomacy, and development. While they need this training to perform their jobs, it also can make them seem out-of-touch with common people who tend to value lived experience over "book smarts." IO staff also hail from a diverse mix of foreign countries and thus do not represent the "true people" that populists privilege, that is, the native, working-class members of their country (Mudde and Rovira Kaltwasser 2017; Copelovitch and Pevehouse 2019; Carnegie, Clark, and Zucker 2024).

This perception is reinforced by IOs' complex decision-making processes that involve negotiations among member states or appointed representatives (cf. Putnam 1988), and that appear far removed from the general public. IOs have their own rules and norms, with a focus on technical knowledge that seems far removed from people's everyday experiences. The involvement of diplomats, bureaucrats, and other high-ranking officials, who interact with multinational corporations, governments, and influential state actors, contributes to these perceptions of privileged and exclusive groups making decisions that affect—but are not shaped by—ordinary people.

In addition to appearing as elite organizations, IOs threaten populists' prioritization of state sovereignty because they explicitly seek to constrain and alter state behavior (Keohane 1984; Copelovitch and Pevehouse 2019). IOs establish norms, standards, and rules for their members that encompass a wide range of issues, including human rights, trade, environmental protection, and security. IOs often enforce these regulations through monitoring, reporting, and applying international pressure.[9] They gather data, conduct investigations, and publish reports highlighting violations or areas of concern. Many have formal dispute-resolution mechanisms to adjudicate potential violations of their rules. IOs also offer economic incentives to influence state behavior, such as financial assistance, trade benefits, or market access.

These activities help IOs encourage states to adhere to their agreements and facilitate cooperation, yet they also drive populist anger because they constrain states' behavior. Populists often feel that the areas IOs govern should fall within states' purviews. They see these institutions as lacking